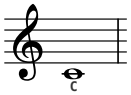Theory reference book, Grades 1–5

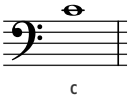
Everything to look up in one place: clefs, note values, time and key signatures, scales, intervals, chords, cadences, ornaments, instruments and terms.

1. CLEFS AND MIDDLE C
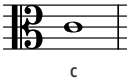
Find middle C first, then count steps up or down. Landmarks: treble G is the 2nd line; bass F is the 4th line.



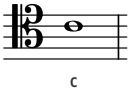
Treble: ledger line below



Bass: ledger line above



Alto (Grade 4): middle line



Tenor (Grade 5): 4th line

LINES AND SPACES

Clef	Lines (bottom to top)	Spaces (bottom to top)
Treble	E G B D F	F A C E
Bass	G B D F A	A C E G
Alto	F A C E G	G B D F
Tenor	D F A C E	E G B D

2. NOTE VALUES AND RESTS

A dot adds half the note's value; a second dot adds half of that again (Grade 4). Triplets: 3 in the time of 2. Duplets: 2 in the time of 3.

Note		Rest	Crotchet beats
breve (Grade 4)			8
semibreve			4
minim			2
crotchet			1
quaver			½
semiquaver			¼
demisemiquaver (Grade 3)			⅛

3. TIME SIGNATURES

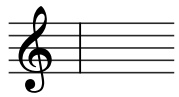
Top number: how many beats (in compound time, beats × 3). Bottom number: the kind of note (2 minim, 4 crotchet, 8 quaver, 16 semiquaver). Halve every note → bottom number doubles.

	Duple (2 beats)	Triple (3 beats)	Quadruple (4 beats)
Simple: beats split in 2	2/2 · 2/4 · 2/8	3/2 · 3/4 · 3/8	4/2 · 4/4 · 4/8
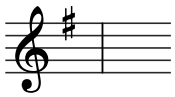
	Duple (2 beats)	Triple (3 beats)	Quadruple (4 beats)
Compound: dotted beats split in 3	6/4 · 6/8 · 6/16	9/4 · 9/8 · 9/16	12/4 · 12/8 · 12/16
	5/4 · 5/8 (2+3 or	7/4 · 7/8 (2+2+3	

4. KEY SIGNATURES
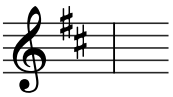
Sharps go F C G D A E B; flats go B E A D G C F. Sharp keys: last sharp + one semitone. Flat keys: the second-to-last flat (one flat = F major). The relative minor is 3 semitones below the major (degree 6).
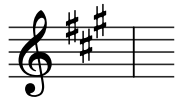


C major · A minor
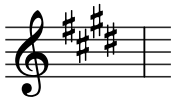


G major · E minor
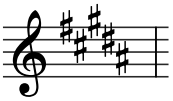


D major · B minor
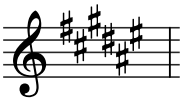


A major · F♯ minor
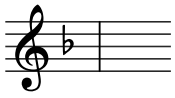


E major · C♯ minor
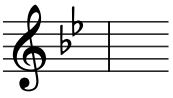


B major · G♯ minor
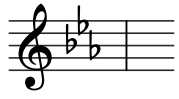


F♯ major · D♯ minor
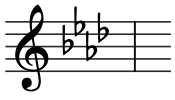


F major · D minor
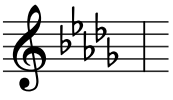


B♭ major · G minor
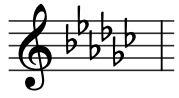


E♭ major · C minor



A♭ major · F minor
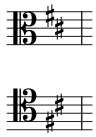


D♭ major · B♭ minor
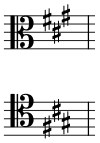


G♭ major · E♭ minor

KEY SIGNATURES IN ALTO AND TENOR CLEF (GRADES 4–5)
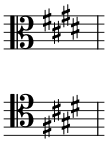
Top: alto clef. Bottom: tenor clef. In tenor clef the first sharp sits low (on the 2nd space up).
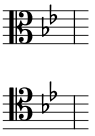


D major
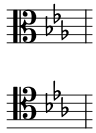


A major
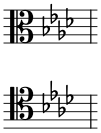


E major



B♭ major
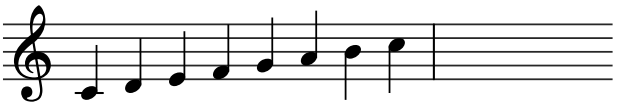


E♭ major
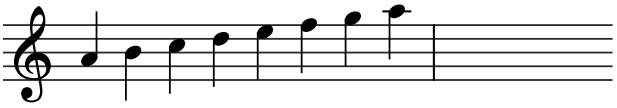


A♭ major

5. SCALES
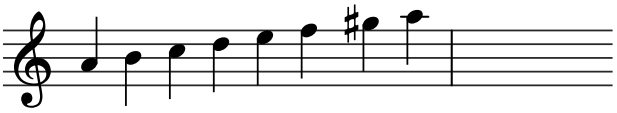
Harmonic minor has an augmented 2nd between degrees 6 and 7. A chromatic scale uses the same letter no more than twice in a row and never skips a letter.
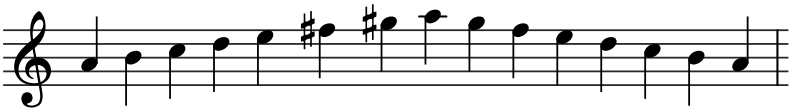


C major: tone tone semitone, tone tone tone semitone
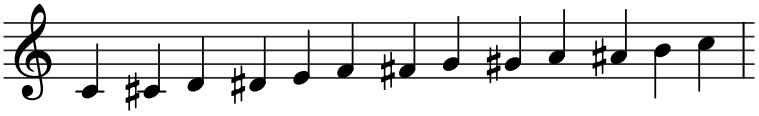


A natural minor (no changes)



A harmonic minor: raise the 7th, up and down (G♯)



A melodic minor: raise 6th and 7th going up, back to normal coming down



Chromatic scale on C (Grade 4): every semitone, each letter at most twice
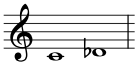
TECHNICAL NAMES OF THE DEGREES (GRADE 4)
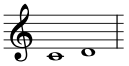
Degree	Name	In C major
1	tonic	C
2	supertonic	D
3	mediant	E
4	subdominant	F
5	dominant	G
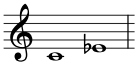
Degree	Name	In C major
6	submediant	A
7	leading note	B
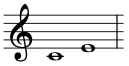
6. INTERVALS ABOVE C
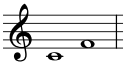
Count letter names for the number (C to G = 5th). Then count semitones for the quality. Major made one semitone smaller = minor; perfect or major one bigger = augmented; perfect or minor one smaller = diminished (Grade 5). Above an octave = compound (9th = octave + 2nd).
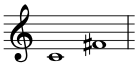

minor 2nd · 1
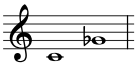

major 2nd · 2
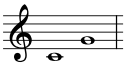

minor 3rd · 3
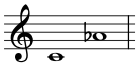

major 3rd · 4
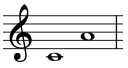

perfect 4th · 5
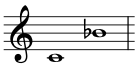

augmented 4th · 6

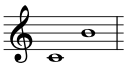

diminished 5th · 6
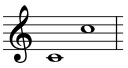

perfect 5th · 7
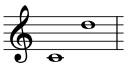

minor 6th · 8
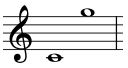

major 6th · 9


minor 7th · 10


major 7th · 11

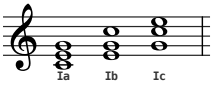

perfect octave · 12


major 9th · 14
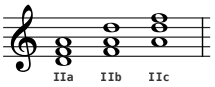

perfect 12th · 19

7. CHORDS AND INVERSIONS IN C MAJOR (GRADES 4–5)

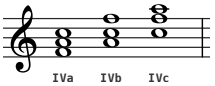
a = root in the bass, b = 3rd in the bass, c = 5th in the bass. In a minor key, chord V has the raised 7th: in A minor, V is E–G♯–B.



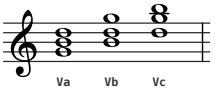
Chord I



Chord II
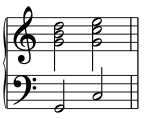


Chord IV
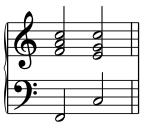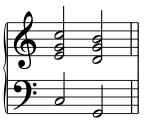


Chord V

CADENCES (GRADE 5)

Cadence	Chords	Sounds
Perfect	V – I	finished, like a full stop
Plagal	IV – I	finished, softer: the 'Amen'
Imperfect	I, II or IV – V	unfinished, like a comma
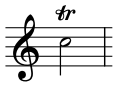

Perfect V–I in C


Plagal IV–I in C
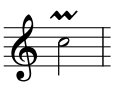

Imperfect I–V in C

8. ORNAMENTS (GRADE 4)
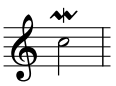
Acciaccatura: tiny note with a slash, crushed in as fast as possible. Appoggiatura: small note without a slash, takes part of the main note's time.
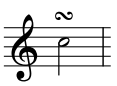


Trill: rapid alternation with the note above



Upper mordent: note, note above, note



Lower mordent: note, note below, note



Turn: above, note, below, note

9. TRANSPOSING INSTRUMENTS (GRADE 5)

Instrument	Sounds	So the part is written	Key signature
Clarinet in B♭, trumpet in B♭	a major 2nd lower	a major 2nd higher	2 flats fewer (or 2 sharps more)
Clarinet in A	a minor 3rd lower	a minor 3rd higher	3 sharps more (or 3 flats fewer)
Horn in F, cor anglais	a perfect 5th lower	a perfect 5th higher	1 sharp more; horn often has no key signature
Double bass	an octave lower	an octave higher	same
Piccolo	an octave higher	an octave lower	same

INSTRUMENTS AND VOICES

Score order, top to bottom: woodwind, brass, percussion, strings.

Family	Instruments (high to low)	Clefs
Woodwind	piccolo, flute, oboe, clarinet, cor anglais, bassoon	treble; bassoon bass (tenor for high notes)
Brass	trumpet, horn, trombone, tuba	treble; trombone and tuba bass
Percussion	timpani, xylophone, glockenspiel, side drum, cymbals, triangle	timpani bass
Strings	violin, viola, cello, double bass, harp	violin treble; viola alto; cello bass (tenor high)
Voices	soprano, alto (contralto), tenor, bass	treble; bass for bass voices

10. TERMS BY GRADE

Grade 1

allegro: fast, lively
andante: at a walking pace
adagio: slow
moderato: at a moderate speed
allegretto: fairly quick
lento: slow
rallentando (rall.): gradually getting slower
accelerando (accel.): gradually getting faster
a tempo: back to the original speed
crescendo (cresc.): gradually getting louder
diminuendo (dim.): gradually getting quieter
mezzo forte (mf): moderately loud
pianissimo (pp): very quiet
fortissimo (ff): very loud
legato: smoothly
staccato: detached
da capo (D.C.): repeat from the beginning
fine: the end
cantabile: in a singing style
dolce: sweetly
poco: a little
molto: very, much
forte (f): loud
piano (p): quiet
ritardando (ritard., rit.): gradually getting slower
decrescendo (decresc.): gradually getting quieter

Grade 2

presto: very fast
largo: slow and stately
vivace: lively, quick
dal segno (D.S.): repeat from the sign
più: more
meno: less
sempre: always
subito: suddenly
tenuto: held
grazioso: gracefully
con moto: with movement
ritenuto (rit.): held back
sforzando (sf): forced, with a sudden accent
mezzo piano (mp): moderately quiet

fortepiano (fp): loud, then immediately quiet
prestissimo: as fast as possible
ottava (8va): play an octave higher

da capo al fine: repeat from the beginning and stop at Fine
ma: but
non: not

troppo: too much
con: with
alla marcia: in the s

Grade 3

ma non troppo: but not too much
espressivo: expressively
leggiero: lightly
maestoso: majestically
sostenuto: sustained
tranquillo: calmly
giocoso: playful, merry
energico: with energy

tempo primo: at the first speed
pesante: heavily
marcato: emphatic, accented
risoluto: boldly
semplice: simply
vivo: lively, quick
delicato: delicately
l'istesso tempo: at the same speed

Grade 4

assai: very
rubato: with some freedom of time
agitato: restless, worried
animato: animated, lively
scherzando: playfully, jokingly
con sordino: with a mute
senza: without
stringendo: gradually getting faster
allargando: broadening, getting slower
mesto: sad
pizzicato: plucked
arco: with the bow
una corda: press the soft pedal
lent: slow (French)
vite: quick (French)
modéré: at a moderate speed (French)

larghetto: rather slow (less slow than largo)
con brio: with vigour, lively
tempo comodo: at a comfortable speed
deciso: decisively
affettuoso: tenderly
tre corde: release the soft pedal
simile: in the same way
come prima: as before
animé: animated, lively (French)
retenu: held back (French)
douce: sweet (French)
alla breve: two minim beats in a bar
amabile: lovable, pleasant
appassionato: passionately
misterioso: mysteriously
ritmico: rhythmically

Grade 5

morendo: dying away
sotto voce: in a hushed voice, very quietly
langsam: slow (German)
schnell: fast (German)
mässig: at a moderate speed (German)
ruhig: peaceful (German)
lebhaft: lively (German)
ad libitum (ad lib.): at choice, freely
quasi: as if, almost
smorzando (smorz.): dying away in tone and speed
perdendosi: dying away, fading

attacca: go straight on to the next section
a niente: dying away to nothing
traurig: sad (German)
cantando: singing
con dolore: with grief
doloroso: sorrowfully
largamente: broadly
con spirito: with spirit
rinforzando (rf, rfz): reinforcing, with a sudden accent
sonoro: resonant
sforzato (sfz): forced, accented
tristamente: sadly